Foundations

How to sit, shape your hands, and find your way around the keys.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Welcome to the piano
2. Sitting at the piano
3. Hand shape and finger numbers
4. The map of the keyboard
5. Finding C and Middle C
6. The musical alphabet
7. The Doxology
8. Jesus Loves Me

1. Welcome to the piano

How this app works, and your very first note.

Hello, pianist

Every great pianist started exactly where you are now. These lessons go one small step at a time, from how to sit all the way to real classical pieces.

Each lesson mixes three things: a short read, a picture, and practice on your piano. When it's time to play, this app **listens through your phone's microphone** and waits until it hears the right note. There's no timer and no rush.

Stand your phone on the music stand, sideways, and turn the volume up a little so you can hear the examples.

Turning on listening

Tap the **microphone button** at the top right. Your phone will ask for permission the first time. Allow it.

When listening is on, the little meter next to it moves when you play. If you don't have a piano handy, you can always tap the keys on screen instead.

Tip: practice in a quiet room. A TV or conversation in the background can confuse the listening.

Practise · Play any white key

Press any white key on your piano, firmly and clearly. Watch the screen light up when it hears you.

2. Sitting at the piano

Bench height, distance, and a relaxed body.

Your seat

Good posture makes everything easier and prevents aches.

- Sit on the **front half** of the bench, facing the middle of the keyboard.
- Your **elbows** should be about level with the keys. Raise or lower the bench, or use a cushion.
- Sit far enough back that your elbows are slightly in front of your body when your hands are on the keys.
- **Feet flat** on the floor (or on a box if they don't reach).

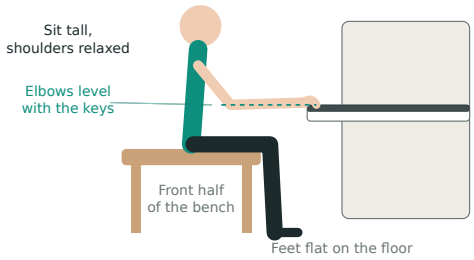


Figure 1.1 · Your seat

Stay loose

Tension is the enemy of good playing. Before every practice session, try this:

1. Roll your shoulders back and let them drop.
2. Let your arms hang by your sides and shake out your hands.
3. Take one slow breath, then lift your hands to the keys.

If anything starts to hurt while you play, stop and shake out again. Short, relaxed practice beats long, tense practice.

> **Review**
>
> Where should you sit on the bench?
>
> **Answer:** On the front half The front half lets your feet stay grounded and your arms move freely.

> **Review**
>
> Your elbows should be…
>
> **Answer:** About level with the keys Level elbows let your forearms rest naturally, with no reaching up or down.

3. Hand shape and finger numbers

The "bubble" hand, and naming fingers 1 to 5.

The bubble hand

Let your hand hang by your side. Notice how the fingers curve naturally? That's the shape you want at the piano.

Imagine holding a **bubble** under your palm. Fingers are curved, you play on the **tips** (not the flat pads), and your wrist stays level, neither drooping nor high.

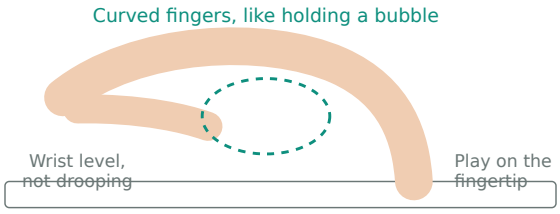


Figure 1.2 · The bubble hand

Finger numbers

Piano music numbers your fingers so it can tell you which one to use. On **both hands**, the thumb is **1** and the pinky is **5**.

Try it now: hold up both hands and wiggle finger 3 (middle) on each. Then 1, then 5, then 2, then 4.

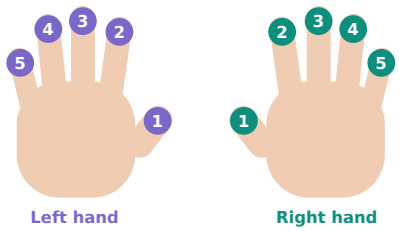


Figure 1.3 · Finger numbers

> **Review**
>
> Which finger is number 1?
>
> **Answer:** Thumb The thumb is always 1, on both hands.

> **Review**
>
> Which finger is number 4?
>
> **Answer:** Ring finger Count from the thumb: 1 thumb, 2 index, 3 middle, 4 ring, 5 pinky.

Finger warm-up

Rest your right hand on a table in the bubble shape. Tap each finger in turn: **1 2 3 4 5**, then back **5 4 3 2 1**. Keep the other fingers relaxed and touching the table.

Now do the same with your left hand. Fingers 4 and 5 feel weak at first. That's normal and gets better quickly.

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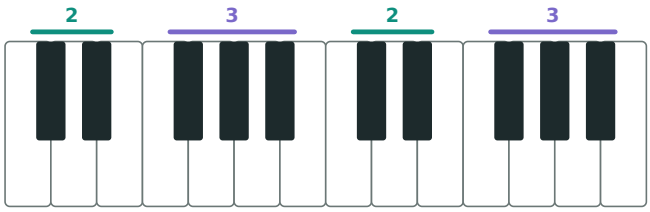
4. The map of the keyboard

Black keys come in groups of two and three.

Twos and threes

A piano can look like a sea of identical keys, but there's a simple pattern. The **black keys** come in groups of **two** and **three**, over and over, all the way up.

These groups are your map. You'll find every note by looking at where it sits next to them.
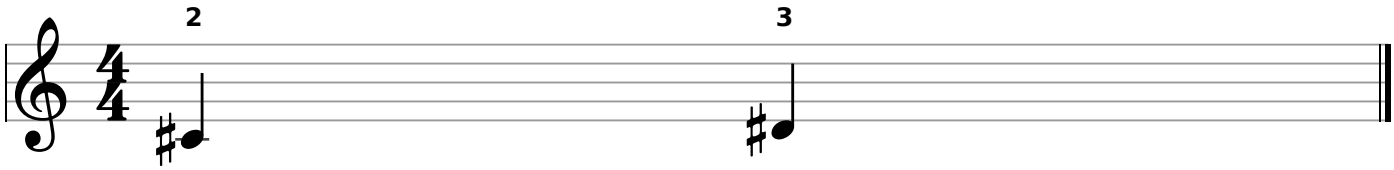


Black keys repeat: a group of 2, then a group of 3

Figure 1.4 · Twos and threes

Practise · A group of two

Find a group of TWO black keys near the middle of your piano and play both, one after the other.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A group of three

Now find the group of THREE black keys just to the right, and play all three, left to right.

Low and high

Play a few keys at the far left of your piano, then the far right. Left is **low** (deep, rumbly sounds). Right is **high** (bright, tinkly sounds).

Moving right is called moving **up**. Moving left is moving **down**.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Which note is higher, the first or the second?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** The second The second note was further to the right, so it sounds higher.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen again. Which is higher this time?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** The first The first note was higher. Training your ear like this helps you catch your own mistakes.

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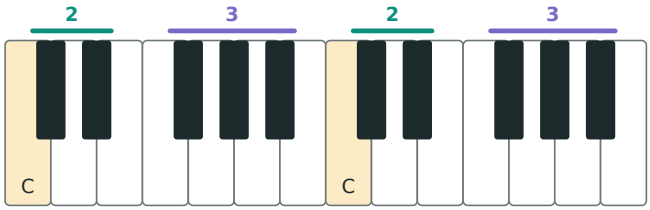
5. Finding C and Middle C

Your home base on the keyboard.

C lives left of the two

The white key just **to the left of every group of two black keys** is called **C**.

There are several Cs on your piano, one for every group of two.

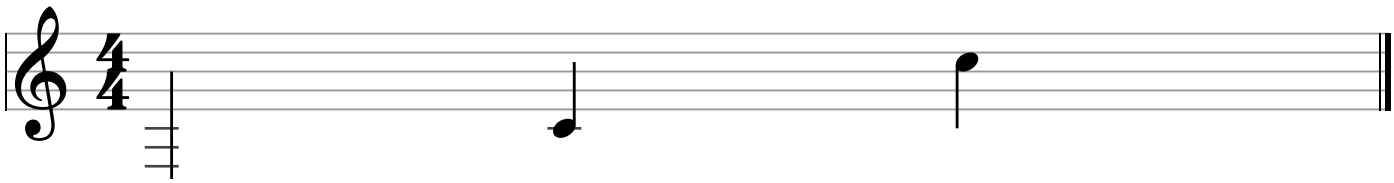


Every C sits just left of a group of two black keys

Figure 1.5 · C lives left of the two

Practise · Play some Cs

Play three Cs: one low, one in the middle, one higher. Any order is fine.

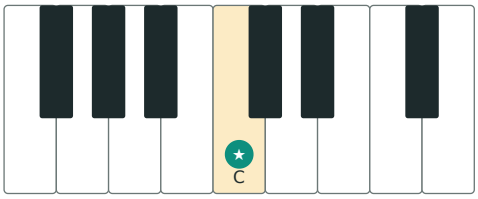


Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Middle C

The C closest to the middle of your piano (usually right in front of you, often under the brand name) is called **Middle C**. Musicians also call it **C4**.

Middle C is home base. Almost every beginner piece starts near it.



Middle C is the C nearest the center of the piano

Figure 1.6 · Middle C

Practise · Play Middle C

Play Middle C with your right thumb (finger 1), four times.

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6. The musical alphabet

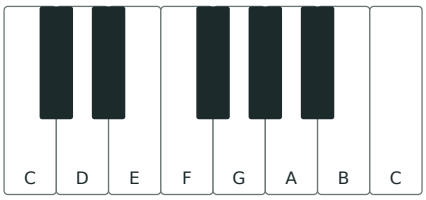
Seven letters, A to G, then repeat.

Only seven letters

Music uses just seven letters: **A B C D E F G**. After G, it starts again at A.

Starting from C, the white keys go **C D E F G A B**, then the next C. The black keys get their names later.

Tip: **D** sits in the middle of the two black keys, and **F** is just left of the three.

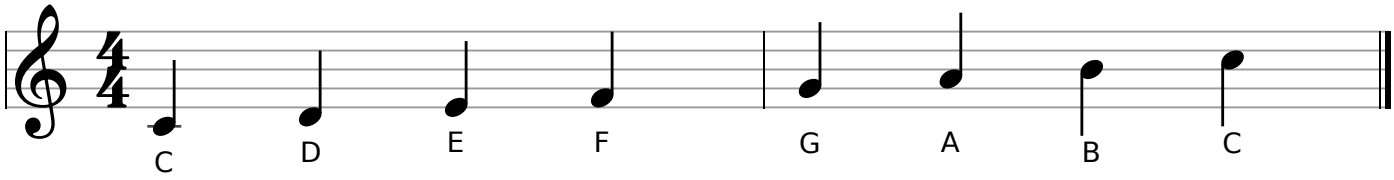


C D E F G A B, then C again

Figure 1.7 · Only seven letters

Practise · Walk up from Middle C

Starting on Middle C, play every white key going up until you reach the next C. Say each letter out loud as you play.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · And back down

Now walk back down from C to Middle C, naming each note.

> **Review**
>
> What letter comes after G?
>
> **Answer:** A After G the alphabet starts again at A.

> **Review**
>
> Which white key sits between the two black keys?
>
> **Answer:** D D is "in the doghouse" between the two black keys.

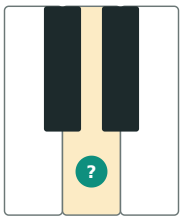


Figure 1.8 · Lesson illustration

Practise · Find the notes

Labels are off now. Find these notes near Middle C: D, then F, then A. Use the black keys as your map.

7. The Doxology

Your first piece: the opening of a 450-year-old hymn tune.

Your first recital

Every unit ends with a **recital**: a piece to practice and then perform from start to finish, with no hints from the keyboard.

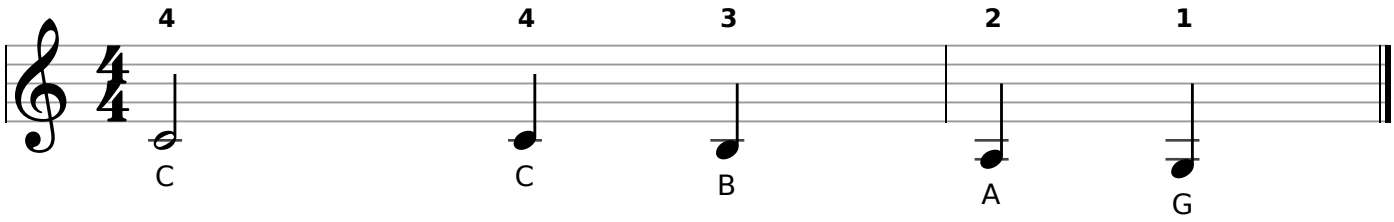
Your first piece is the opening line of the **Doxology** ("Praise God, from whom all blessings flow"). Its tune, called **Old Hundredth**, was published in Geneva in 1551 and has been sung ever since.

The first half walks **down** the white keys from Middle C: C C B A G. Then your thumb hops back to Middle C and walks **up**: C D E.

This is the start of a longer journey: each unit adds a little more of the Doxology, until you can play the whole hymn with both hands.

Practise · Walking down

Put finger 4 on Middle C. Walk down: C C B A G, ending on your thumb.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Walking up

Move your thumb to Middle C and walk up: C D E. Hold the last note.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole line, with hints. Tap Listen to hear how it should sound.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

8. Jesus Loves Me

A gentle children's hymn that climbs a little higher.

Jesus Loves Me

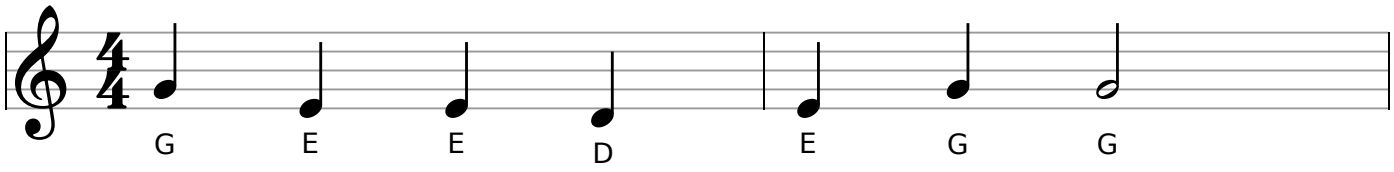
Anna Bartlett Warner wrote these words in 1860, and William **Bradbury** gave them their tune two years later. It has been sung by children all over the world ever since.

The verse starts on **G** and leans down to E: "G E E D E G G". Then it reaches up to **A** and the high **C**.

Your hand will need to move a little. Follow the note names on the keys, and don't worry about which finger plays which note yet.

Practise · Verse, first half

"Jesus loves me, this I know, for the Bible tells me so."



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Verse, second half

"Little ones to Him belong; they are weak, but He is strong." It ends back on Middle C.

Practise · The chorus

"Yes, Jesus loves me…" Hold the long notes for their full count.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

Verse and chorus together, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- [ ] Set up the bench and relax my shoulders, wrists, and hands.
- [ ] Name fingers 1 to 5 on both hands.
- [ ] Use groups of two and three black keys to find C and Middle C.
- [ ] Name the white keys and recognize whether notes move higher or lower.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
